11/25 WED — THE COSTCO PARKING LOT SCAMS

Airdate Wed Nov 25, 2026 · tapes Fri Nov 20 · A only (one long story) · no guest · 1 break · Stage: videos

SUMMARY

The most dangerous minute of a Costco run is in the parking lot: arms full, trunk open, purse in the cart. Police say organized crews wait for exactly that minute, with a "gift" necklace that swaps out your real gold, a purse grabbed while you load and your cards drained before you get home, "real gold" sold for gas money, a car that suddenly won't start, and a tracker stuck under your bumper. Jeff loves Costco, so he's going after the people working its parking lots, then six moves that protect you every time you load the car.

THE SHOW

1. Tease (opens on clip 1: the 86-year-old's daughter: "They're putting this gift around dad's neck as they're somehow removing his chain")
2. TWO STRANGERS PUT A "GIFT" ON THIS 86-YEAR-OLD… AND TOOK HIS GOLD (clip 1)
3. THE SAME TRICK TOOK A TUSKEGEE AIRMAN'S RING… AND POLICE GOT IT BACK (clip 2)
4. THEY'LL GRAB YOUR PURSE WHILE YOU LOAD THE CAR (clip 3)
5. THEY CAN DRAIN YOUR CARDS BEFORE YOU EVEN GET HOME (clip 4)
6. //// Break: generic ad lead-in
7. A STRANGER OFFERS YOU "REAL GOLD" FOR GAS MONEY… IT'S NOT GOLD (clip 5)
8. YOUR CAR WON'T START… AND THE "HELPERS" ARE ALREADY WAITING (clip 6)
9. SOMEONE COULD PUT A TRACKER ON YOUR CAR WHILE YOU SHOP (clip 7, demo)
10. HERE'S HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF
11. Close

THE TEASE

A1 · the hook

- Two friendly strangers help an older man load his groceries… then hang a "gift" necklace around his neck.
- By the time they drive off, his real gold is gone. And it all happened in a Costco parking lot.
- You're going to meet his family, and see how the same trick took a Tuskegee Airman's ring, and how police got it back.
- Then the crews who grab your purse while you load the car, and drain your cards before you get home.
- Plus the one thing to do before you put a single bag in the trunk.

TWO STRANGERS PUT A "GIFT" ON THIS 86-YEAR-OLD… AND TOOK HIS GOLD

A2 · San Jose, CA (Costco) · Aug 2026

- I love Costco. So when I hear crews are working its parking lots, I want to stop them.
- This couple had just finished their grocery run and popped the trunk.
- Two women walked right up and started loading the groceries for them. He said thanks, he could do it himself.
- So what happened next?

CLIP 1 (HORIZONTAL): NBC Bay Area — Elderly San Jose couple robbed of treasured heirloom in coordinated parking lot theft · Aug 2026 · 2:30

- **0:29–0:55 ("WE HAVE TO HELP THE ELDERLY") // BUTT 1:16–1:54 ("TEMPORARILY BLOCKED THEM FROM LEAVING")**
- *Soundbite: "It was the end of their grocery run... when they popped the trunk of their car, two women immediately began loading their groceries... 'I can do it by myself. I don't need help, thanks.' But he said that they told him, 'God says we have to help the elderly.'" // "...one woman then followed the husband as he got in the car and gave him a necklace. 'They're putting in this gift around dad's neck as they're somehow removing his chain.'... stealing his 18-karat gold medallion, an heirloom given to him by the priest who married them more than 50 years ago... another car with at least two men in it pulled up behind their car and temporarily blocked them from leaving."*

- **Out:** An heirloom from the priest who married them, gone in seconds, and a second car blocking them in. That's not a random thief. That's a crew.
- **Red flag:** a stranger who insists on helping you load the car, or wants to put something on you. Step back and say no.

THE SAME TRICK TOOK A TUSKEGEE AIRMAN'S RING... AND POLICE GOT IT BACK

A3 · Renton, WA (Walmart) · Feb 2026 · ⚠️ old case

- And it's not just one parking lot. Police are seeing this same move up and down the West Coast.
- Outside a Walmart near Seattle, a woman offered this 71-year-old man five dollars, then said she just wanted to bless him.
- His necklace held a ring that belonged to his brother, a Tuskegee Airman. So what did she do?

CLIP 2 (HORIZONTAL): FOX 13 Seattle — Police arrest alleged crime group accused of 'blessing' jewelry thefts · Feb 2026 · about 6:00

- **1:32–2:14 ("PILOTS IN U.S. HISTORY") // BUTT 3:23–3:45 ("THAT BELONGED TO MY BROTHER")**
- *Soundbite: "We talked and next thing I know, a $5 bill popped up and she told me, take this... Oh no, I just want to bless you... Undeterred, police say she moved to put this cheap necklace around his neck... while she was clamping it around my neck. That's how she stole this off of my neck... His necklace held three rings, including one that belonged to his brother, Otis Forman, a member of the Tuskegee Airmen..." // "Detectives got a search warrant for the vehicle and found Ricki's stolen necklace for him... that was the only thing I really cared about. Was getting the ring back. That belonged to my brother."*
- ⚠️ LEGAL: the woman and her group are accused, not convicted; they pleaded not guilty (4:00, outside the cut). The package names the group's nationality in its first minute; the cut and the copy don't.

- **Out:** They got his brother's ring back. I love it when police step in like that. But not every story ends that way.
- **Red flag:** "I just want to bless you," and a hand reaching for your neck. Walk away.

THEY'LL GRAB YOUR PURSE WHILE YOU LOAD THE CAR

A4 · Vallejo, CA (Costco) · Aug 2025 · ⚠️ old case

- But it gets worse: some crews don't bother with a trick at all.
- This woman was loading her groceries into her car in a Costco parking lot.
- A car parked nearby was recording the whole thing. Watch what happens.

CLIP 3 (HORIZONTAL): NBC Bay Area — Woman robbed in Costco parking lot in Vallejo · Aug 21, 2025 · 0:27

- **0:00–0:27 ("ABOUT AN HOUR LATER"), WHOLE CLIP**
- *Soundbite: "New video from a Tesla shows a woman robbed as she loaded her groceries... this is the Costco parking lot in Vallejo. A masked man approaches her, throws her to the ground... takes off with her purse. The woman then gets up and actually chases after him. Police say two minors were arrested... the pair robbed another woman the same way in another parking lot two miles away about an hour later."*
- ⚠️ LEGAL: the suspects are minors (unnamed, not shown); keep it that way.

    - ⚠️ UNVERIFIED: timed from a Whisper transcript of the site video. No YouTube copy found, so the site link stays.
- **Out:** Knocked to the ground, for a purse. And another woman, an hour later, two miles away.
- **Red flag:** your purse in the cart or on the seat while your back is turned. That's the moment they wait for.

THEY CAN DRAIN YOUR CARDS BEFORE YOU EVEN GET HOME

A5 · Portland, OR (Costco) · May 2024 · ⚠️ old case

- But it gets worse: once they have your wallet, they move fast.
- Police in Portland released this video from a Costco parking lot. Watch the three men behind this 93-year-old.
- He was home in about half an hour. So how much had they spent by then?

CLIP 4 (HORIZONTAL): KATU News — 93-year-old Portland man pickpocketed; thieves used credit cards to buy $100s in gift cards · May 2024 · 1:16

    - **0:19–0:38 ("$1,500 ON VISA GIFT CARDS") // BUTT 0:59–1:05 ("OLDER MORE VULNERABLE PEOPLE")**
    - *Soundbite: "...you can see three men follow the victim out of the store walking closely behind him. One of them takes the wallet from the man's back pocket. Now police say the suspects used his credit cards within 30 minutes of the theft. This is video from a Fred Meyer where they spent $1,500 on Visa gift cards." // "Now police say the suspects seem to be targeting older, more vulnerable people."*
- **Out:** Fifteen hundred dollars in gift cards, within half an hour. Before he even knew his wallet was gone.
- **Red flag:** gift cards are the first thing they buy. If your wallet's gone, call your card companies before you leave the lot.

//////////////////

BREAK — generic ad lead-in. *Next:* the stranger selling "real gold" for gas money, and the car that won't start right when two helpful men show up.

//////////////////

A STRANGER OFFERS YOU "REAL GOLD" FOR GAS MONEY... IT'S NOT GOLD

A6 · Mettawa, IL (Costco) · Mar 2026 · ⚠️ old case

- Now they're not grabbing your money. They're getting you to hand it over.
- In a Costco parking lot outside Chicago, a man said he needed money to get to the airport.
- The next day he had jewelry to sell.
- Police say one shopper paid fifteen thousand eight hundred dollars for it. Then police set up in that same lot.
- It's the same script in parking lots across the country. So what are they really selling?

CLIP 5 (HORIZONTAL): KOAA 5 — Don't be fooled by parking lot fake gold scheme · date unconfirmed · 2:33

    - **0:29–0:50 ("IT'S WORTHLESS") // BUTT 0:52–1:12 ("IT'S ACTUALLY BRASS")**
    - *Soundbite: "...customers come in over the last couple weeks who say they've been approached by men in this very parking lot looking to make a transaction. They want to trade gold necklaces, bracelets and rings for gas money, effectively cash, but it turns out what people are getting in this transaction isn't gold at all. In fact, it's worthless." // "...the people approaching them sound desperate. They say they just need money to get home or get their vehicle gassed up or even fixed. People who take the deal believe they are buying valuable jewelry that is 18-karat gold, when in fact it is only worth a couple of cents at best, because the experts say it's actually brass."*
    - ⚠️ WEAK: no upload date (YouTube blocked the lookup), and Colorado Springs police said no reports had been filed there. The Mettawa loss rests on one secondary source.
- **Out:** Brass, worth a couple of cents. And in Illinois, police say two men pleaded guilty. This is organized, and it's the same story every time.

- **Red flag:** a hard-luck story plus a deal on "real gold," cash only. Never buy jewelry in a parking lot.

YOUR CAR WON'T START... AND THE "HELPERS" ARE ALREADY WAITING

A7 · Lehi, UT (Costco) · Jun 2026

- And now they're getting to you before you even leave the store.
- This woman came out of a Costco in Utah, got in her car, and it wouldn't start.
- Two men parked nearby were happy to help.
- One opened the fuse box and said he could fix it, for two hundred dollars. So what did police find on the parking lot cameras?

CLIP 6 (HORIZONTAL): ABC4 Utah — SCAM Alert! In Utah County, people are being targeted in parking lots · date unconfirmed · 1:04

  - ⚠️ THROTTLED: YouTube blocked the captions on two tries, so there's no in–out yet. Re-run the caption fetch before the bible.
  - ⚠️ MANUAL alternate: the woman's own TikTok, @jasnahooke (447K+ views per Motor1; the post's URL isn't published). TikTok blocks requests from here.
- **Out:** They broke her car, then offered to fix it. She says police saw them on the lot cameras, going under her car.
- **Red flag:** your car worked when you went in, and the help is already standing there. Stay in, lock the doors, call for help yourself.

SOMEONE COULD PUT A TRACKER ON YOUR CAR WHILE YOU SHOP

A8 · Auburn, AL (Sam's Club / Walmart) · Sep 2025 · ⚠️ old case

- And now it's not just your purse. This one can follow you home.
- This woman was driving home from shopping when her iPhone popped up a warning she'd never seen before.
- It said a tracking device was moving with her, ever since the Sam's Club parking lot.
- So what did her brother find under her car?

CLIP 7 (HORIZONTAL): WTVM — Tracker found underneath woman's car in Auburn · Sep 15, 2025 · 3:13

  - **0:47–1:20 ("ALL OVER FROM WHERE I WENT") // BUTT 1:20–1:41 ("REPORT IT TO LAW ENFORCEMENT")**
  - *Soundbite: "I was riding home yesterday and I got a notification on my iPhone and it said tracking notification... shocked to find this small GPS tracker with audio capabilities underneath her car... it said that it started pinging my phone at 4:50 at Sam's Club and it was still continuously tracking me and it tracked me back home to my mom's house and then all over from where I went." // "Bedford said she believes the tracker was placed on her car while she was at Walmart in Opelika... investigators... say if anyone finds a suspicious tracker on their vehicle to immediately report it to law enforcement."*
  - ⚠️ UNVERIFIED: timed from a Whisper transcript of the site video (site metadata said 32:05; real length 3:13). No YouTube copy found.

DEMO (show-produced): Jim Stickley hides a tracker on a car; Jeff's iPhone and an Android phone both alert, and Jeff shows where to check: the license plate, the fuel door, the wheel wells.

- **Out:** Her phone caught it. Yours can too, if one setting is on. I'll show you in a minute.
- **Red flag:** "found moving with you" on your phone. Don't drive home. Drive somewhere busy and call police.

HERE'S HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF

A9 · the fix

1. **PURSE IN THE CAR FIRST... THEN LOCK THE DOORS WHILE YOU LOAD** (the one thing from the tease)
   - Before a single bag goes in the trunk, your purse or wallet goes inside the car, and the doors get locked.
   - Never leave a purse in the cart or on the seat while your back is turned.

2. **NEVER LET A STRANGER PUT ANYTHING ON YOU**
    - Not a necklace, not a scarf, not a hug, not a "blessing." Step back and say no.
    - Leave the good jewelry at home, or tuck it in when you shop.
3. **SAY NO TO HELP YOU DIDN'T ASK FOR**
    - A stranger insisting on loading your groceries is the setup, not a favor.
    - Never buy jewelry, gift cards or anything else in a parking lot. Walk away before money changes hands.
4. **WALLET GONE? CALL YOUR CARD COMPANIES BEFORE YOU LEAVE THE LOT**
    - They're buying gift cards within minutes. Every minute counts.
    - Turn on purchase alerts on every card so you see a charge the second it happens.
5. **CAR WON'T START? STAY INSIDE AND LOCK THE DOORS**
    - Call roadside assistance or police yourself. Never let a stranger work on your car.
6. **TURN ON TRACKER ALERTS ON YOUR PHONE** *(demo)*
    - iPhone: Settings, Notifications, Tracking Notifications, on. Bluetooth and Location Services have to be on too.
    - Android: Settings, Safety and emergency, Unknown tracker alerts. Tap Scan now for a check anytime.
    - Find one? Don't drive home. Go somewhere busy and call police.

CLOSE

- Send this to someone who shops at Costco, before their next trip.
- The next video to watch. See you next time.

BUILD SHEET

For Claude and the pipeline. The room can skip this page.

Spine

- **In one sentence:** Crews work big-box parking lots in the minute your arms are full and your trunk is open, with fake gifts, purse grabs, fake gold, sabotaged cars and trackers; put your purse in the car and lock the doors before you load, and never let a stranger help, touch or sell.
- **Hold back:** the purse-first, lock-the-doors move (step 1) and the tracker setting (step 6). The tease promises "the one thing to do before you put a single bag in the trunk"; it doesn't say what.
- **Peg:** the busiest shopping weekend of the year (airs the day before Thanksgiving; Black Friday Nov 27), with the Sacramento County Sheriff's warning on jewelry distraction thefts at Costco, Sam's Club, Walmart, Lowe's and Home Depot (Jul 27, 2026) and Boone County, WV's Nov 1, 2026 lot tips. The copy stays evergreen (Jeff, 11/11): no holiday, Black Friday or season in any spoken line; it lives in the title, thumbnail and description.
- **Climb:** less you can do, closer to you: a trick you can refuse (A2–A3) → no trick, just force (A4) → the damage spreads before you're home (A5) → they get you to hand it over (A6) → they get to your car while you're inside (A7) → they follow you home (A8) → you take it back.
- **Framing:** a stranger in a store parking lot while you shop or load your car. Costco leads (A2, A4, A5, A6, A7); Walmart, Sam's Club and others build it out. Never "panhandlers": every case is a crime that takes money, jewelry, a purse or your safety.
- **Open package:** clip 1, the daughter: "They're putting this gift around dad's neck as they're somehow removing his chain."
- **Payoff point:** A9 (step 1, purse in the car first).
- **Weight:** 100% of show · 7 clips.

Beats

Beat	Clip	Who	Tag	Status	Adds	Search specifics
A1	—	You (the viewer)	JEFF	—	—	—
A2	1	Couple, 86 and 75, and their daughter, San Jose CA (Aug 2026)	FIND · HORIZONTAL	PICK	evidence: the real result, a crew	NBC Bay Area, Mayra Franco; YouTube qR0sQsMqBJc (captions); Costco at Almaden Plaza; 18K medallion from the priest who married them; second car blocked them in; SJPD news release Aug 25, 2026 (three arrested for chain-snatch robberies)
A3	2	Rickey Foreman, 71, Renton WA	HAVE · HORIZONTAL	PICK · LEGAL	development: organized, and caught	FOX 13 Seattle YouTube X_pAsqSPpgY

		(Feb 2026)				(captions); Bellevue PD Special Enforcement Team; Renton Walmart Supercenter; brother Otis Foreman, Tuskegee Airman; necklace recovered; theft 1st degree; not-guilty pleas
A4	3	Woman loading groceries, Vallejo CA (Aug 2025)	HAVE · HORIZONTAL	PICK · LEGAL · UNVERIFIED	evidence: caught on camera, force	NBC Bay Area video page (NBCStations, 0:27), Tesla camera; two minors arrested; second robbery two miles away an hour later
A5	4	Man, 93, Portland OR (May 2024)	HAVE · HORIZONTAL	PICK	stakes: cards drained in 30 minutes	KATU YouTube XgkNrTUgYgU (captions); Portland PD; Costco NE Portland; Fred Meyer, $1,500 Visa gift cards; WinCo PIN watching; Det. Jordan Zaitz (KOIN)
A6	5	Shopper, Mettawa IL (Mar 2026)	HAVE · HORIZONTAL	WEAK	development: they get you to hand it over	Wealth of Geeks via Yahoo Aug 2, 2026; Lake and McHenry County Scanner; $15,800; stakeout; two guilty pleas; clip KOAA YouTube bF4ysj53h7U (captions), Colorado Springs pawn shop owner Reed Robbins; alt KREM HXvfyXqtIoU

						(captions blocked)
A7	6	Jasna (@jasnahooke), Lehi/American Fork UT (Jun 2026)	FIND · HORIZONTAL	THROTTLED	development: they get to your car while you shop	ABC4 Utah YouTube kUy077XD5To (captions blocked twice); Motor1 Jun 28, 2026; 2017 Corolla; fuse pulled; $200; American Fork PD warning Jun 2025; TikTok @jasnahooke 447K+ per Motor1; second Utah Costco case Sep 2026 (The Mary Sue, gas door open, two men)
A8	7	Kansas Bedford, Auburn/Opelika AL (Sep 2025)	FIND · HORIZONTAL	PICK · UNVERIFIED	stakes: they follow you home	WTVM site video (ArcPublishing, real length 3:13), Justin Brown; iPhone tracking notification; first ping 4:50 at Sam's Club; believes placed at Opelika Walmart; magnetic GPS tracker with audio; Fort Wayne alt WPTA lOy9S2jWGOE
A9	—	You (the viewer)	DEMO	—	—	—

Jeff should know

- A2: NBC's video ran before any arrests ("we have not yet received a response" from police). San Jose police announced three arrests in chain-snatch robberies on Aug 25, 2026; the reporting doesn't tie them to this couple. Don't say they were caught.
- A2: the couple spoke Spanish; the daughter's bite is the English one. They reported it to San Jose police.
- A3: February 2026. Three arrested, a fourth charged; all pleaded not guilty. Police and FOX 13 name a nationality; we say "an organized group."
- A4: August 2025. The suspects are minors; never name or describe them beyond "two teenagers."

- A5: May 2024. Police say the same group watched shoppers enter PINs inside a WinCo, then stole wallets in the lot.
- A6: the Mettawa case (Mar 2026) comes from one secondary write-up (Wealth of Geeks on Yahoo, crediting a local scanner page). Confirm with the Lake County State's Attorney before Jeff says "$15,800" or "pleaded guilty." The clip is Colorado Springs, a different case.
- A6: dead list: "parking lot panhandling hustles." Keep this beat on the loss, the fake gold and the police work; no confrontation videos.
- A7: the police-footage detail is her account (via Motor1); confirm with Lehi or American Fork police, or say "she says."
- A8: September 2025. Motive unknown: say "someone," never "thieves." She believes it was placed at the Walmart; it first pinged at Sam's Club.
- Costco is the hero's store, not the villain: nobody says its lots are less safe. Costco's own fraud page warns only about online and phone scams. Ask Costco for comment ("we reached out").
- Collision: Jeff's approved donation tap-to-pay standalone says that scam is "spreading to the busiest parking lots." It's out of this show; if it airs first, one callback line.

The fix: sources

- Step 1: purse in the car, lock the doors while loading (King County Sheriff via KIRO 7, Jun 24, 2019; Portland PD via KOIN, May 24, 2024); trunk purchases, lock every time (Boone County, WV Sheriff via WTAP, Nov 2, 2026).
- Step 2: "never allow strangers to place jewelry, scarves or other items around their necks"; leave valuable jewelry home or covered (Sacramento County Sheriff via Folsom Times, Jul 27, 2026).
- Step 3: never buy jewelry in a lot; report it (Kauai PD, Feb 2025; West Shore RCMP, Mar 2026); be less trusting of flattery (NBC Bay Area shopper, clip 1). ⚠️ "Refuse unrequested help loading" rests on the San Jose case; no police source yet.
- Step 4: card thieves bought gift cards within 30 minutes (Portland PD via KATU); purchase alerts ⚠️ issuer-specific.
- Step 5: stay in your locked car and call police (Culpeper County Sheriff via Fredericksburg Free Press, Aug 10, 2025); never let strangers work on your car (American Fork PD via ABC4, Jun 1, 2025).
- Step 6: iPhone Tracking Notifications, Bluetooth and Location Services (Apple Support); Android Unknown tracker alerts and Scan now (Google Support); report it to police (WTVM, Opelika investigators; KPLC, Sulphur PD). ⚠️ "Don't drive home, go somewhere busy" needs a named police source (SPD's Sarah Lawson, KIRO 7, Nov 2023, is the closest).
- Do-nothing test: the viewer who only locks the doors (step 1) is still exposed to the necklace swap (step 2) and the sabotaged car (step 5); the viewer whose wallet is already gone needs step 4 within minutes.

Gaps

- ⚠️ A3 Renton is February 2026: date in a Jeff note.
- ⚠️ A4 Vallejo is August 2025: date in a Jeff note. Timed on a Whisper transcript of the site video.
- ⚠️ A5 Portland is May 2024: date in a Jeff note.
- ⚠️ A6 Mettawa is March 2026: date in a Jeff note. The clip's date is unconfirmed.
- ⚠️ A7 no transcript: ABC4's captions were blocked twice. The TikTok's URL isn't published.
- ⚠️ A8 Auburn is September 2025: date in a Jeff note. Timed on a Whisper transcript of the site video.
- ⚠️ YouTube view counts and upload dates: not confirmed for any clip (bot wall); NBC Bay Area's San Jose upload showed ~23K in search.
- ⚠️ What our old "3 Costco SCAMS — EXPOSED LIVE!" (SKagNLR5x6M) covered is still unknown.

Open calls

- A3 LEGAL: the accused pleaded not guilty; the copy says "police say" and "accused." Approve.
- A4 LEGAL: the suspects are minors (unnamed, not shown). Approve.
- A6 WEAK and the dead list: keep the fake-gold beat framed as organized fraud (Mettawa, if the source holds), or cut it?
- A7 THROTTLED: re-fetch ABC4's captions before the bible, or pull the TikTok by hand. A fresher option is the September 2026 Utah Costco case (gas door open, two men watching).
- The demo (A8): book Jim Stickley for the Fri 11/20 taping?
- Costco on the record: ask for comment?
- Watch our old "3 Costco SCAMS" video before the bible, so no case repeats.
- The tap-to-pay donation standalone: when does it air?
- Sponsor spots for the break.